officer-like qualities, or OLQs, required to become an officer. When we talk about OLQs, we talk about effective intelligence, reasoning ability, power of expression, self-confidence, determination, organizing ability, initiative, courage, cooperation, a sense of responsibility, stamina, group influencing ability, liveliness, social adaptability and speed of decision: qualities that an officer must have in order to lead men into battle, some of which can be gained through day-to-day experiences and learning, while others must be naturally present, inherited or imbibed. A number of SSB training centres groom thousands of defence aspirants to effectively perform in SSB. But I had never visited any. I couldn't help but think of how the other candidates appearing with me might have either had prior experience of SSB interviews or training from some institute, which would narrow down my chances of being recommended.

I had never wondered if I possessed those OLQs until I boarded the train. What does a twenty-year-old girl, who had just waded through the toughest and most confusing years of life, know about it anyway? Self-introspection is not meant to be in the nature of the young and the restless—they are meant to make mistakes, fall, rise, experience and learn, before they are finally old enough to sit back and pass verdict on their younger selves. And I was still quite young, and a lot more restless. But the whole SSB thing and Papaji's words triggered a downpour of memories and I couldn't help but think about what my parents had always told me—that I was different. They would back this up with memories and events from even before I was born. *That's where you belong . . . on the edge*.

The year 1974 was an eventful one in India's history. Under Project Smiling Buddha, India had successfully conducted its first nuclear test in the Thar desert, workers of the Indian Railways had created history with the largest industrial strike recorded in the world, and there was an outbreak of smallpox in Bihar, Orissa (now Odisha) and West Bengal. And somewhere in the army cantonment of Guwahati in Assam, Mrs Kirti Saxena, mother-to-be, had just survived eight months with a swollen belly. After going through nausea and vomiting, fatigue, backache and headache for endless days and nights, she watched with a sense of delight as her second child